Game Design Document (GDD)

[The Paper Elite]

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Changelog

- **Physical Prototype:**
  - **Core genre and mechanics:** The core gameplay loop is a fusion of *Punch-Out* and *Slay the Spire*, themed around dark humor
  - **Theme and setting:** Will be using a 2D paper-based aesthetic and narrative
  - **Enemy behavior:** Made the initial boss behavior logic (using a 1d6 to determine which action the boss will use)
  - **Battle rewards:** Ideas for how post-battle loot, which includes deck-thinning (rolling a 1d4 for a chance at card removal), works
  - **Physical prototype:** Made the physical prototype of the game
  - **Rules and combat:** Wrote the instructions for the physical prototype and mapped out the combat loop
- **Testing:**
  - **Block clarifications:**
    - *Issue:* Playtesters were confused about how block reduced damage
    - *Change:* Rewrote rules surrounding "Block"
    - *Result:* Reduced player confusion, improving game flow
  - **Combat loop refined:**
    - *Issue:* The turn structure wasn't made with multiplayer in mind
    - *Change:* Implemented back and forth between the player team and enemies, where the player acting on the player turn descends down the player turn order
    - *Result:* Allows multiple players to play at a time without messing up game balance
- **Digital Prototype:**
  - **Game pacing:**
    - *Issue:* Boss rush felt repetitive and lacked true choices for players
    - *Change:* Moved away from a pure boss-rush to using an interconnected map styled after the *Path of Exile* skill tree
    - *Result:* Increased replayability and player agency
  - **Scope reduction:**
    - *Issue:* The physical prototype contained too many systems to fully implement in a digital format within the time constraints
    - *Change:* Only implemented the core combat loop and essential mechanics, while simplifying or omitting secondary systems
    - *Result:* More polished prototype
  - **System Translation (Physical → Digital)**
    - *Issue:* Physical systems relied on manual tracking (dice rolls, counters, card handling, etc.)
    - *Change:* Replaced these physical systems with automated systems and UI elements
    - *Result:* Faster gameplay and reduced player micro

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1. Introduction

1.1. Scope of the document

Who's this document meant for? Who'll read it? The dev team? Stakeholders? Investors?
This document is meant for the development team of The Paper Elite, to be able to understand the game as a whole and where the direction of the game is. The dev team, as well as some stakeholders, will be reading this document.

1.2. Elevator pitch

Tell what your game is about in less than 75 words and why it is a promising idea.
The Paper Elite is a roguelike card game with the humor of Cards Against Humanity. The game follows a dystopian 2d world where people from our world "slip" down a dimension. The elite who have "slipped" kept their control, but over time have grown bored and implemented a tournament. The prize: a way home. The cost of losing: you disappear. This game makes light of and allows people to laugh at the rich and powerful, while still enjoying a fun, strategic card game.

2. Game Overview

2.1. Game concept

A summary of the game and gameplay. What's the objective of the game? What do you want your players to feel while playing it? What's the main thing they'll be doing? What will they enjoy?
The objective of the game is to reach the final boss on a map of enemy encounters. Players chart their own course through the map, fighting enemies and collecting items as they go. Most of the players' time will be spent in encounters, using their deck of cards that they build along the map to fight enemies of increasing difficulty. Outside of these encounters, players will use strategic thinking to choose their route through the map, what items and cards they choose to upgrade their power, and more. Much of the game (cards, enemies, items, etc.) will be themed around dark humor, as the intent of the game is to provoke thought into the state of our society (and laugh at it) while still enjoying a fun card game.

2.2. Audience

What are the characteristics of the people who'll play the game? What's their age range? What genres do they like? What similar games do they play? Everything that you know about them and most importantly, *how do you know these people will actually buy your game?*
The target audience of this game is fans of roguelike games and people who enjoy dark humor. For the roguelike aspect, people who play games like Slay the Spire, Balatro, Inscryption, and more are likely to enjoy this game. As for the dark humor portion, people who like Cards Against

Humanity, Jackbox, and your average Instagram reels enjoyer will likely enjoy this game. The game is intended to not only appeal to the overlap of these two given groups, but both groups as a whole. To do this, the roguelike strategic elements should stand on their own without the humor, and the humor should be funny enough to stand alone on its own without the roguelike portion, and should be accessible enough that it does not rely on incredible skill to experience. The likely age range for this game is 16+, given the themes the humor will delve into.

2.3. Genre

What genre would this game be cataloged as? Tower defense, FPS, Puzzle Platformer?
This game is a Roguelike Deckbuilder.

2.4. Setting

Where does the game take place? Medieval world? Fantasy world? Real world? Real world but with fictional events? An alternate reality where something from the past never happened?
The Paper Elite takes place in a 2d world dystopia, accessed from our 3d reality by the process known as slipping (the act of falling through the fabric of our 3d reality and getting turned 2d in the process). The elite of our world who have “slipped” kept their control, but over time have grown bored and implemented a tournament. The prize: a way home. The cost of losing: you disappear.

2.5. World structure

How does the player navigate the world? Do they move linearly through levels? Is it an open world that they can explore freely?
The player navigates through the map (which is shaped like a path of exile skill tree) in an open world fashion, going to whatever fights and events that they want (may need move cap).

2.6. Player

Who will the player play as? Is it singleplayer or multiplayer? Ex: “Each player plays as one of four knights, each of which has an elemental affinity. Up to four players can play at a time. (Castle Crashers)"
Each player plays as one of four members of the 2d world, who slipped from the 3d world. These 2d people are all non-unique, starting with the same decks.

2.7. Core loop

The very basic actions the player takes when playing the game: Moving and shooting, running and jumping, reading and picking dialogue options, drawing and playing a card, etc.
The core game loop of this game is split between combat and mapping. In combat, players draw cards each turn, spend energy, and do actions like attacking, defending, or using specials.

Between fights, they pick new cards and items, and choose which paths to follow to ultimately craft their deck into a boss-killing machine.

2.8. Look & Feel

Look refers to the game's visual style (graphics, animations, color wheel, etc.). Feel refers to the playability and the parts of the game that can affect the user, such as story or music. And something important to remember: the “look” influences the “feel”. You can use images of other games/media as a reference.
The look of the game will be that of a cartoon, with the feel of the game being cartoonish. The cartoonish elements will allow me to 1) lighten the topics being joked about, as they are often serious topics, 2) more effectively mock the people I’m trying to mock, and 3) use cartoonish tropes (hammerspace mostly) in a context that makes sense.

3. Gameplay

3.1. Objectives

What is the main objective for the player? And what are the secondary objectives? Ex: The main objective is beating the final boss in the final level, the secondary objectives are fetching the hidden pieces in the earlier levels, discovering the story secrets through the map and beating the secret boss.
The main objective of the player is to beat the final boss at the center of their map without dying. There are no secondary objectives.

3.2. Progression

How will the player progress throughout the game? It can be anything from how they advance to the next area to how the leveling influences the world around the player.
The player progresses through the game by defeating enemies on the map in the way of the direction they want to traverse. In doing this, this unlocks more of the map for the player to access. Additionally, rewards are obtained upon defeating an enemy, and there are nodes on the map that grant the player additional rewards/items.

3.2.1. Difficulty curve

A somewhat optional section, use this if the difficulty setting of your game is not as simple as different attribute values, as for example, if the enemy learns from the player’s actions and adapts to them, and how it will affect the progression of the game.
Not applicable.

3.3. Play flow

Similar to the Core Loop section, here you’ll detail the expected flow of gameplay from the player’s perspective, not just the core loops of it. Mention if they are expected to do a

couple of side missions before a main one, if they will gather collectibles to enhance their abilities at a specific point in the game, etc.
Choose a node to go to that is accessible from your current unlocked map area. If an item/event node, perform node actions. If a combat node, enter combat. Combat consists of an enemy turn, then a player turn, repeating until combat ends. Turn order for the players is determined, and the player whose turn it is in turn order takes a player turn, going down the play order, and looping back after the last in order. Combat ends when the boss's health reaches zero or when the player team's health reaches 0. During a player's combat turn, they will draw and play cards from their personal deck, using them to attack the enemy, block enemy attacks, and enact special abilities that can affect the player and/or the enemy. Once combat ends, if the players are still alive, they collect their rewards from the battle, then exit to the map. Repeat the cycle until the final boss is dead or the players' team health reaches 0.

3.4. Difficulty

How will the difficulty of the game affect gameplay? How many different levels of difficulty will be implemented?
There is only one difficulty option for the game, but enemy difficulty scales the closer you get to the center of the map (where the final boss is).

4. Mechanics

Most of the time, you will customize this section of the GDD to each of your games. For example, if your game has combat in it, you want to include a segment of "Combat" and one for "AI", or if your game has a unique system for spawning, you'll want to mention how it works.

4.1. Rules

The general rules of the game, what are the limits of the player's actions.
The player is limited in the map to pathing to nodes adjacent to nodes they have previously traveled to (recursing back to an initial starting point). They are able to make decisions on item and event nodes on the map, and use their combat actions in combat.

4.2. Game universe

How the game universe works. Mention here the stuff that is done outside of the perception of the player, like restocking inventories of key NPCs.
Enemy combat action order is determined by a set, repeating action order or by random selection of all possible actions. The decided action for the subsequent combat turn is then displayed.

4.3. Physics

The overall physics of the world. Is it realistic? Low gravity? Destroyable environment?
Not applicable (point and click controls)

4.4. Economy

Does your game have an economy? What is the currency? How many currencies does it have? How does the player gain and lose currency? How is it balanced?
Not applicable.

4.5. Character movement

The range of movement that the player has within the game world.
As mentioned before, the player is limited in the map to pathing to nodes adjacent to nodes they have previously traveled to (recursing back to an initial starting point).

4.6. Player interaction

What can the player interact with?
As mentioned before, the player is able to make decisions on item and event nodes on the map and use their combat actions in combat.

4.6.1. Game menus

A brief mention on how the game menus work and what options are available to the player.
The game menu has continue (exits menu), settings, save, and exit game

4.6.2. Saving

How will saving work with the game? Are there save points? Can the player save anywhere?
The game autosaves at the end of each run, and the player can save and quit a run to continue later at any point they are on the map and not performing an action.

4.6.3. Game options

What options can the player change from the menus?
The player can access accessibility settings and change their input mapping.

4.7. Assets

A list of the main assets that the game will use, split by type: “Player Model, Player Texture, Enemy Model, Terrain Material, Enemy Death Sound, etc.
Not applicable (greyboxing currently)

4.8. Combat

1. Combat Setup
    a. Each Player shuffles their deck
    b. The Team block and energy pools are reset to their default values (0 and 4)

    c. The Players collectively determine their order for the next combat. This order goes from 1 through X (X = # players). If a decision cannot be made, each player rolls 2d6, and turn order goes from highest to lowest, rerolling on ties.
2. Combat
    a. Combat consists of an enemy turn, then a player turn, repeating until combat ends. The player whose turn it is in turn order takes player turn, going down the play order, and looping back after the last in order. (eg. if there are 4 players, the turns go p1, enemy, p2, enemy, p3, enemy, p4, enemy, repeat) Players share health, block, and energy pools, and all counters/damage/etc affect these group pools.
    b. Terminoligy
        i. Block: when a player or enemy with block takes damage, they take 1 less damage for each block counter they have, up to the number of damage attempting to be dealt. After taking damage, remove X block, where X is the amount of damage prevented. All team block is removed at the start of a player's turn. All enemy block is removed at the start of the enemy's turn.
    c. Enemy Turn
        i. Remove any remaining enemy block
        ii. Decrement all counters on the enemy by 1
        iii. Play queued action (if any), and flip it face down (Note: on turn 1, the enemy will not play an action; it will only queue one)
        iv. Determine the next queued action and display it.
        v. Trigger any end-of-turn effects caused by any counters on the enemy
    d. Player Turn
        i. Set energy to default (4) and block to 0
        ii. Decrement all counters on the team by 1
        iii. Draw 5 cards from your draw pile
            1. If your draw pile is empty and you need to draw, shuffle your discard pile, place it face down, and draw any remaining cards. If you played a card that caused you to draw from an empty draw pile, set this card aside while you shuffle, and add it to the new (now empty) discard pile
        iv. Play your cards, paying the energy cost in the top left-hand corner of the card. When a card is played, resolve its effects and place it face up in your discard pile. Keep track of energy on the energy board.
        v. When the player would like to end the turn, they declare this and place their hand face up in their discard pile
        vi. Trigger any end-of-turn effects caused by any counters on the player
3. End of Combat
    a. Combat ends when the boss's health reaches 0
    b. Determine Rewards:
        i. The reward pool for each combat consists of each of the boss's action cards and a card removal. Each reward can only be chosen once, and

each player gets one reward. Players do not have to choose a reward, and can just pass their turn in the reward choice order. Reward choice order is determined by player consensus. If consensus cannot be reached, each player rolls 2d6, and reward order goes from highest to lowest, rerolling on ties

5. Graphics and audio

5.1. Visual system

An overall mention of how the visuals of the game will work, and if there's a reason behind it. Is it 2D or 3D? Cell-shaded, minimalistic or realistic?
The game is a 2d game, with cartoonish visuals. The cartoonish elements will allow me to 1) lighten the topics being joked about, as they are often serious topics, 2) more effectively mock the people I'm trying to mock, and 3) use cartoonish tropes (hammerspace mostly) in a context that makes sense.

5.1.1. Player camera

How will the player see the game? If you have different types of cameras, mention them.
The player sees the world through a camera that switches between the map and combat at the appropriate times.

5.1.2. Landscape

What will the landscapes of the game look like? This is extremely important if your game is a platformer.
The background of the game will be different areas of a colosseum, where the Games take place.

5.2. Interface

What will the user interface look like? How will the player interact with it? How will it affect gameplay?
The user interface will consist of indicators for player energy, health, block, and status conditions, enemy attack, block, and status conditions, the player's current hand, draw, and discard piles, and player item information.

5.3. Audio system

An overall mention of how the audio of the game will work, and if there's a reason behind it. If your game has in-game voice chat, be sure to include it here.
The game has sound effects for when actions are performed.

5.3.1. Game music

What type of music will you use in the game? This segment can be quite large for some games that have music as one of their main assets for gameplay/storytelling.
Not applicable (greyboxing currently), but not central to the game.

5.3.2. Audio look & feel

What does the game's audio want to convey? How is it going to feel for the player? Tense? Whimsical? Transmit a feeling of dread?
I want the audio to convey the sense of danger the players are in as they battle in the Games in the colosseum. There is danger, but also excitement at the prospect of freedom.

6. Story and narrative

6.1. Backstory

What events of interest happened before the start of the game?
See setting for more context. In the land of Paperville, where everyone is as thin as paper, there exists a deadly tournament. Officially, it is called "The Paper Games", but we commonfolk mockingly refer to it as "The Elite." Because that's who always wins. And if you lose, well, they take you. It's all laid out in the contract that you agree to; they'll provide for you, train you, to become "better", to become "stronger." It's all a lie, though, it's gotta be. No one ever comes back. They say if one of us wins, the winner is allowed to use the Elite portal -- go back to the real world. There's only ever been one winner, back in the early days of the game, back when I still had color in my beard. He went by Kay. He was one of the first of us; both he and I came here from the same Slip. He had a fire like I'd never seen before, a need to break out, to escape. He is the one who made it out, the only one. That fire rarely appears nowadays, around once a chapter. You have that fire. You have the courage. And you have the need. So go, train, face the elite, make it out, get us help, so one day we may all be free.
(NAMING PENDING, I KNOW THEY'RE BAD)

6.2. Main plot

What's the main plot of the game? Just write the most important stuff here in a condensed form, remember that this is a game design document, not a web novel.
The main plot of the game is participating in the games in the city colosseum. The player fights through enemies, powering up and getting loot. Their goal is to reach and defeat the final boss, but to do so, they must fight their way through multiple act bosses that gate progression forward in the map.

6.2.1. Plot progression

How will the plot progress throughout the game?
See Main Plot

6.3. Cutscenes

Don’t mention specific cutscenes (Just do it if they are extremely relevant to the game), only mention how you will use cutscenes in gameplay.
Not Applicable

7. Characters

7.1. Main characters

Who are the main characters in the game? If you have more than one, then add a small description of all subpoints from this segment for each one of them.
The Player(s) are the main characters of the game. Character details are left intentionally vague, as character development occurs in the development of a player’s playstyle. This style of character development allows the player to become the character and choose how they develop, instead of the traditional cutscene narration.

7.1.1. Backstory

One of many unwilling residents of Paperville, having taken a Slip from the real world, and in the process, turned nearly two-dimensional. You were lucky; you didn't change too much otherwise when you fell through. But you want out. When you landed, the Wise One found you, helped you understand your situation, and took you under his wing. You've done your research, you tried to find another way, but like all those before you, you found yourself eventually training for the games. Now you're ready, The Wise One said you're ready, so go, enter the collesium.

7.1.2. Personality

Not applicable

7.1.3. Appearance

Generic random 2d human.

7.1.4. Abilities

Starts with none, is just your average athletic human.

7.1.5. Relationships

Trained by The Wise One, doesn't like The Elite

7.2. Supporting characters

Who are the supporting characters? As with the supporting characters, you don’t have to include all main character’s subpoints, except if the enemy description plays a huge part in the overall plot of the game.

The Wise One: an old sage, who slipped long before anyone currently in Paperville. He never attempted the games, but has been coaching contestants as far back as people can remember. How he takes it, seeing generation after generation of paperians fall victim to the Elite...

7.3. Enemies

Who are the main enemies? You don't have to include all the previous subpoints for this one, just a brief description of them.
The Elite: a cabal of the rich, powerful, and famous that slipped early on. They seized power, locked up the portal, and started hosting the games. It seems like they like it here and would rather stay in their tower than go back to the real world.

8. Game world

8.1. Look & Feel of the world

Similar to 2.8, but in this case, you're just talking about the game world, not the game in general.
The player's map is enclosed in a colosseum, with the player starting at the edge of the arena. Combat encounters proximity to the center of the colosseum changes the encounter backgrounds to reflect that proximity. The world is your typical dystopian world, where the rich and powerful live in excess, their enforcers live well, and the rest of the population lives in squalor.

8.2. Locations

What are the most important locations in the game and how will they be relevant to the game?
Paperville: The name given to the main city of the 2d world. The colosseum: the location where The Paper Games take place.

8.2.1. Connection to the plot

Explained in previous points, including Backstory and Main Plot

8.3. Levels

Just as each one of their names says, briefly describe the levels of the game (If there's any).
Not applicable

8.3.1. Tutorial levels

Not applicable

8.3.2. Main levels

Not applicable

8.3.3. Optional levels

Not applicable